Then the Yatra transcended time and age, reaching the land of Mahakal, Ujjain. There was also a day of rest. In a large public meeting, Rahul ji, emphasizing his accumulated experiences in the journey and natural wisdom, said this is a land of ascetics. Rama, Nanak, Gautama, Mahavira, Krishna, Kabir and Gandhi were all ascetics, as are those engaged in hard physical labour. In that sense, farmers, pastoralist societies, indigenous people, women, artisans, weavers, labourers, skilled youth, sanitation workers and entrepreneurs all practise asceticism. Even walking is a form of tapasya. With every step we take on the road, we descend inwards.

When the Yatra commenced from Ujjain, it had a different flavour. Rahul ji decided that he would spend an entire day exclusively in dialogue with women in every state. Every day during the journey, he conversed with writers, journalists, university professors, athletes, democratic activists and party workers. It wasn't easy to keep pace with his energy. An unwavering enthusiasm propelled him forward. Many times, the conversations were so intriguing that we didn't even realize when we had reached the Yatra's destination. But the discussions were yet to conclude.

In the same sequence, it was decided to engage in dialogue with women throughout the day. The sisters of a self-help group arrived promptly at 5.30 a.m. Women were standing on both sides of the road. Even young children waved their hands, breaking through the crowd to enter. Their innocent questions and comments relieved the fatigue of the day. It had been long since a leader of feminist sentiments and camaraderie had been found with whom women could share their pain so effortlessly. Bapu was rich in such feminist empathy. His equality could not be matched. But Rahul ji exhibited the same ease, humility, compassion and feminist perspective as Bapu. Otherwise, can such a pure, natural and compassionate dialogue be possible in a patriarchal society? He heard with great compassion the troubles of managing households due to domestic quarrels, violence and inflation. He stopped for tea at 5 p.m. and openly discussed his childhood and school days. It did not feel like meeting any leader. It felt like it was an informal conversation with a very close friend.